

DECOUPLING BETWEEN THREAT AND PROTECTION



Material signals, political priorities and loss of orientation

1. THE STARTING POINT: AN ALREADY RECOGNIZED SIGNAL

In 2015, the Paris Agreement politically consolidated a finding that already had broad scientific support: the rise in global temperature constituted a sufficiently serious threat to require a coordinated, sustained response aimed at limiting its effects.

Since then, the climate issue can no longer be regarded as an unknown signal or a future possibility. There is an explicit political reference point from which the subsequent trajectory can be assessed.

Eleven years later, the initial signal has not disappeared. **It has expanded.**

Thermal pressure is now compounded by disruptions to the water cycle, prolonged droughts, extreme precipitation, wildfires, agricultural losses, impacts on infrastructure, economic costs, and direct effects on health and habitability.

Therefore, the situation in 2026 is not equivalent to that of 2015.

Time has passed, evidence has accumulated, and certain material conditions have changed.

This introduces a fundamental difference between **political horizon and material state**.

A political objective can be revised, postponed or replaced.

The territory does not automatically return to the state from which that objective was formulated.

Each period spent on an insufficiently corrected trajectory can reduce the margin available for later action, increase recovery costs, and make some losses partially irreversible.

The question is no longer only whether Europe recognizes climate change.

The question is:

How capable is that recognition of changing priorities when material signals intensify?

In 2015, temperature helped justify a horizon of correction.

In 2026, temperature and water simultaneously affect health, agriculture, energy, infrastructure, the economy, territory and security.

If these variables do not occupy an equivalent position in the hierarchy of decision-making, the problem is no longer a lack of knowledge.

It is the distance between **what is known, what is happening, and what ultimately organizes political action.**

2. THE THREAT IS NO LONGER SECTORAL

Temperature and water are often treated politically within specific categories: climate, environment, adaptation, transition or resilience.

However, their material effects do not remain within those administrative boundaries.

Temperature simultaneously affects health, productivity, energy demand, agriculture, wildfires, infrastructure, habitability and water availability.

Water, in turn, can appear as prolonged deficit, reduced availability, lower flows or drought; but also as sudden excess, extreme precipitation, flooding and destruction.

Therefore, the problem cannot be reduced to “more” or “less” water.

It is a matter of **availability, distribution, intensity, timing and territorial absorption capacity.**

This makes temperature and water **cross-cutting variables.**

They do not compete with the economy, security, sovereignty, infrastructure or competitiveness as if they were simply two additional priorities on a list.

They condition them.

An economy requires water, energy, functional territory and a population able to work and live.

Infrastructure requires thermal and hydrological conditions compatible with its design and maintenance.

Public security includes wildfires, floods, heatwaves, water availability and habitability.

Sovereignty also depends on the material capacity to sustain population, production, territory and infrastructure.

This is why there is a difference between:

incorporating climate as a sector

and

incorporating climatic conditions as limits and conditions of all policies.

If temperature and water remain confined to a specific policy area while the rest of the priorities are decided independently of them, the political architecture may be treating as sectoral something that is materially cross-cutting.

The question is not whether a climate policy exists.

The question is:

Can security, competitiveness, sovereignty and investment be defined without first integrating the thermal and hydrological conditions that make them sustainable?

3. DECOUPLING BETWEEN THREAT AND PROTECTION

A protection policy can increase capacities in defense, security, border control, competitiveness, sovereignty or infrastructure.

The problem arises when those capacities are prioritized without present, documented and cross-cutting material threats occupying an equivalent position in decision-making.

In 2026, thermal and hydrological signals are observable and documentable. They simultaneously affect population, territory, economic activity, agriculture, energy, infrastructure and health.

If, despite this, the political response is organized mainly around other priorities, a decoupling emerges between:

the threat materially affecting the system

and

the protection the system chooses to reinforce.

This decoupling does not imply that defense, security or competitiveness measures are unnecessary.

It means that they may be incomplete if they do not incorporate the thermal and hydrological conditions that cut across what they are intended to protect.

Infrastructure protected against external threats remains vulnerable to floods, droughts, wildfires or extreme temperatures.

A competitive economy still depends on water, energy, productivity, transport and habitability.

A security policy still depends on the material capacity to sustain population, territory and essential services.

Therefore:

more protection does not necessarily mean more security.

Protection capacities can increase while the material conditions of security deteriorate.

The problem is not choosing between climate and security.

The problem is defining security broadly enough to include the conditions that make it possible to sustain it.

When those conditions remain outside the center of decision-making, policy can reinforce the architecture without reducing the threat that cuts across that same architecture.

And then the question changes:

Is the system being protected against the reality that is currently placing it under pressure?

STRUCTURAL COMPARISON

MATERIAL SIGNALS (2026)	EXPRESSED PRIORITIES
 Temperature	 Defense and security
 Water	 Borders and migration
 Wildfires and extreme events	 Competitiveness and investment
 Health and population	 Sovereignty
 Agriculture and territory	 Spending cuts
 Economy and infrastructures	 Regulatory simplification

Thermal and hydric conditions affect sectors that do not appear with the same weight in the hierarchy of expressed priorities.

4. EXPRESSED PRIORITIES, ABSENT PRIORITIES

At the end of August 2026, six Member States of the European Union — Germany, Austria, Denmark, Finland, the Netherlands and Sweden — made public a joint position on the next Multiannual Financial Framework.

The proposal calls for a substantial reduction in spending compared with the Commission's proposal and identifies security and defense, competitiveness, migration, sovereignty and regulatory simplification among its priorities.

The relevant question for this analysis is not whether those priorities are legitimate.

It is to observe **what appears and what does not appear with the same weight in the expressed hierarchy.**

In a summer marked by extreme temperatures, drought, wildfires, hydrological disruption, and impacts on health, agriculture, transport and economic activity, temperature and water do not explicitly appear among the stated priorities as equivalent guiding criteria within that prioritization.

This does not allow any intention to be attributed to the signatories.

Nor does it allow us to claim that those states reject European climate policy.

It allows a more limited and verifiable observation:

the material variables that cut across numerous sectors do not occupy an explicitly equivalent position among the stated priorities.

The difference is significant because a budget is not merely a declaration of objectives.

It is a **selection mechanism.**

When resources are presented as limited, deciding which areas are reinforced and which lose weight also determines which risks acquire effective response capacity.

That is why a reduction in the budget introduces an additional question.

If thermal and hydrological conditions are already generating economic, health and territorial costs, **can future financial margin be assessed without sufficiently incorporating the variables that are contributing to consuming that same margin?**

The problem is not that defense, competitiveness or sovereignty policies exist.

The problem arises if those capacities are projected as though the material conditions that sustain them could remain outside the main calculation.

Absence also provides information.

When a threat is cross-cutting, its position within a list of priorities matters as much as its general recognition in other documents.

5. THE COST IS NOT EXTERNAL TO THE BUDGET

Climate conditions do not only generate environmental impacts.

They also generate expenditure.

Prolonged droughts, heatwaves, wildfires, floods and disruptions to the water cycle directly affect agriculture, energy, infrastructure, transport, public health, insurance, productivity and territorial recovery capacity.

Therefore, part of future budgetary pressure cannot be analyzed as though it were independent of those material conditions.

There is a basic relationship:

material deterioration → higher costs → reduced financial margin

When water becomes scarce, the cost of securing supply, sustaining production and maintaining certain sectors increases.

Extreme temperatures can increase costs associated with health, cooling, productivity losses, wildfires and infrastructure deterioration.

When floods or extreme events occur, emergency, repair, reconstruction and compensation costs arise.

This introduces a difficult question to avoid:

Can budgetary margin be reduced without sufficiently integrating the variables that are contributing to consuming that same margin?

Reducing expenditure can be a legitimate decision.

But the balance remains incomplete if it only records how much money remains available and does not give equal weight to what is increasing the need for expenditure.

The relationship can also become cumulative:

more material deterioration

→ **higher costs**

→ **less financial margin**

→ **less capacity for prevention and recovery**

→ **greater future exposure**

The risk does not lie only in having fewer resources.

It lies in reducing response capacity while the conditions generating new costs continue to operate.

That is why temperature and water should not be treated only as environmental categories.

They are also **budgetary variables**.

If they affect production, health, energy, infrastructure and recovery, they necessarily affect public finances.

The budget is not outside the territory. It depends on it.

6. RECOGNIZING CLIMATE CHANGE DOES NOT GUARANTEE INCORPORATING ITS LIMITS

There is a difference between recognizing a threat and allowing that threat to reorganize priorities.

For years, the European Union has recognized the existence of climate change and has had emissions-reduction targets, regulatory mechanisms, adaptation policies and transition strategies.

But that general recognition does not by itself answer a more specific question:

What happens when material signals require a change in the order of priorities?

Temperature and water may be fully present in scientific reports, statistics, media coverage and climate documents.

However, that does not automatically mean they occupy an equivalent position when decisions are made about budget, security, investment, competitiveness, infrastructure or sovereignty.

A separation can then emerge between two circuits.

On the one hand:

material evidence → measurement → knowledge → recognition

On the other:

political priorities → budget → investment → regulation → protection

The problem arises when both circuits remain only partially connected.

In that case, the system can verbally recognize deterioration while continuing to organize its main decisions through a hierarchy that has not substantially changed.

Adaptation, resilience or transition can form part of a legitimate response.

But they can also function as categories broad enough to absorb the evidence without necessarily changing the structural direction.

That is why the relevant question is not:

Is climate change being discussed?

But rather:

How capable is what is being observed of changing what is decided?

When evidence increases but the hierarchy remains stable, a decoupling between **knowledge and orientation** can emerge.

The problem would then not be a lack of information, but an insufficient translation of that information into a change of priority.

And that difference is decisive because the territory does not respond to discursive recognition.

It responds materially to existing conditions.

7. TECHNICAL ACCELERATION AND BIOLOGICAL TIMESCALES

A transformation can accelerate in its technical, financial or administrative components.

Investment, permits, infrastructure deployment, electrification, automation, digitalization or technological substitution can all be accelerated.

But that capacity for acceleration does not automatically transfer to biological, hydrological or territorial systems.

Aquifers have recharge times.

Soils have recovery rates.

Forests require periods of regeneration.

Ecosystems respond through thresholds, inertia and processes that cannot simply be compressed by political decision or additional investment.

Human populations also have physiological and social limits to adaptation.

Therefore, an **“accelerated green transformation”** can only be considered materially coherent if technical acceleration reduces pressure on those underlying bases quickly enough.

It is not enough to increase the speed of transformation.

What matters is the relationship between that speed and the recovery capacity of what sustains the system.

If technical expansion increases while hydrological margin, thermal conditions compatible with habitability and human activity, territorial capacity or social resilience decline, acceleration may reinforce precisely the decoupling it is intended to correct.

The issue is not to oppose technology and biology.

It is to recognize that they operate on **different timescales**.

A political architecture can decide to act faster.

It cannot decide that a degraded territory will recover at the same speed.

Acceleration is only an advantage if it reduces pressure faster than it consumes recovery capacity.

Otherwise, a transformation described as “green” may preserve the language of transition without yet demonstrating an equivalent material return.

The final test is not the color of the policy.

It is the state of the territory.

8. TIME IS NOT NEUTRAL

When a material trajectory remains sufficiently stable, waiting can expand the space for decision-making.

But when underlying conditions deteriorate, time works differently.

Each interval that passes without sufficient reorientation can increase accumulated damage, raise recovery costs and reduce the options available later.

Therefore:

more time does not necessarily mean more margin.

A prolonged drought does not start again from zero each year.

Degraded soil does not automatically recover its previous condition when an emergency ends.

A population repeatedly exposed to extreme temperatures accumulates health, economic and adaptation costs.

Infrastructure repaired after each impact may continue to function while the cost required to maintain it increases.

The territory accumulates the trajectory.

Policy, by contrast, can renew timelines, reformulate objectives, replace programmes or shift horizons to later dates.

This creates a fundamental asymmetry:

political horizons can be reset; material conditions cannot.

The Paris Agreement established a horizon of correction in 2015.

By 2026, eleven years have passed since that reference point.

During that period, technological capacity, connectivity and the speed of numerous economic and technical processes have increased.

But that increase in capacity does not in itself imply a recovery of territorial and human margin.

If the horizon is pushed forward again while starting conditions continue to deteriorate, political distance may increase at the same time as material margin decreases.

The question is not only how much time remains until a future objective.

It is:

What will still remain available to recover when that objective is reached?

Some losses may be reversible.

Others only partially so.

Certain alterations may cross thresholds beyond which recovering a state equivalent to the previous one is no longer possible.

That is why the cost of postponement is not measured only in years.

It is also measured in **lost reversibility**.

A policy can extend its deadlines.

The territory accumulates time.

9. MATERIAL SECURITY

Security is often organized politically around identifiable threats: defense, borders, sovereignty, economic stability, critical infrastructure or institutional capacity.

But a definition of security that does not incorporate temperature, water and habitability is incomplete.

A population may be protected against certain external threats while simultaneously becoming more exposed to heatwaves, wildfires, droughts, floods or declining water availability.

An economy may strengthen its competitiveness while the costs arising from those same conditions increase.

Infrastructure may be strategically protected and still remain vulnerable to temperatures for which it was not designed, water scarcity or extreme precipitation.

Therefore, temperature and water are not an alternative to security.

They are part of security.

The problem arises when priorities are organized as though there were two separate domains:

security, economy and sovereignty

on one side,

and

climate, water and territory

on the other.

Materially, that separation does not exist.

All of them depend on the same territorial base.

Governance, infrastructure, economic activity, technology and population share soil, energy, water and thermal conditions.

That is why protecting one part of the system without incorporating the conditions that cut across the whole may increase certain capacities without proportionally increasing real security.

The question is not how much is invested in protection.

The question is:

What reality is being protected, and against which threats?

A material security policy should incorporate from the outset the conditions required to maintain habitability, population, territory, infrastructure and economic activity.

Only then can it decide which additional capacities need to be reinforced.

Reversing that order can produce a paradox:

more formal protection while the material conditions of what is being protected deteriorate.

Security, therefore, does not begin at the border or in the budget.

It begins with the conditions that allow there to be something that can be protected.

10. GOVERNING MEANS TRANSLATING SIGNALS INTO PRIORITIES

The network can connect information.

Technology can process, model and amplify it.

But neither can replace the political function of governance.

Institutions exist, among other reasons, to receive dispersed signals, assess collective risks, establish priorities and decide how limited resources are distributed.

That is why, when abundant information exists on temperature, water, wildfires, health, agriculture or infrastructure, the issue can no longer be reduced to the availability of knowledge.

The problem shifts elsewhere:

How is that knowledge converted into decision-making?

A signal can be scientifically recognized and politically acknowledged without acquiring sufficient capacity to modify a budgetary hierarchy.

It can be incorporated into specific strategies and still remain subordinate when decisions are made about security, competitiveness, investment or sovereignty.

This mismatch matters because governance is not located outside the territory either.

Institutions depend on population, infrastructure, energy, resources, economic stability and material conditions of habitability.

There is no form of governance capable of remaining indefinitely detached from the degradation of the base it administers.

Therefore, responding to the territory is not an additional priority competing with the rest.

It is part of the very capacity to govern.

An institution can increase regulation, coordination, budgets in certain sectors or administrative capacity and still reduce its effective capacity for orientation if the signals affecting the system as a whole do not sufficiently alter its decisions.

This allows us to distinguish between two different capacities:

management capacity: responding to impacts once they have occurred;

orientation capacity: modifying the conditions that increase the need to respond.

Both are necessary.

But they are not equivalent.

If the first increases while the trajectory generating new impacts remains largely unchanged, governance can become progressively more active while at the same time becoming increasingly constrained by the consequences it must manage.

Governing is not only about responding better.

It is also about preventing the need to respond from increasing indefinitely.

11. FROM SECTORAL PROTECTION TO MATERIAL ORIENTATION

The problem described in these pages does not imply that Europe should replace multiple priorities with a single climate priority.

It implies something different.

Temperature, water and territory cannot simply occupy one more position within a list of objectives because they constitute conditions that cut across the entire list.

Defense, competitiveness, sovereignty, infrastructure, health, agriculture, energy, technology and budgetary capacity all depend on a shared material base.

Therefore, the fundamental question is not:

How much space should be given to climate in relation to other priorities?

But rather:

How should all priorities be organized within the material conditions that make them sustainable?

This change in position alters the meaning of protection.

Protection no longer consists only of reinforcing capacities against identified threats; it also requires preserving the conditions that make it possible to exercise those capacities.

The difference may seem small, but it changes the entire order of decision-making.

In a sectoral model, water and temperature compete for budget with security, competitiveness or infrastructure.

In a materially oriented model, water and temperature form part of the conditions that must be incorporated when defining what kind of security, competitiveness and infrastructure are sustainable.

This is not about stopping all activity, innovation or transformation.

It is about preventing increased capacity from remaining separated from the capacity to sustain it.

Eleven years after the Paris Agreement, with more information, greater technical capacity and broader material evidence, the central question is no longer only how much the European architecture can do.

It is:

Can that capacity be reoriented before the conditions that make it possible to use it deteriorate even further?

The signal exists.

The capacity to observe it also exists.

The pending decision is what position that signal occupies when the time comes to order priorities.

And that position will determine whether protection continues to respond mainly to the existing architecture or begins to respond also to the material conditions that sustain those who inhabit it.

IN SUMMARY: WHAT IS AT STAKE

The decision on the next European financial framework is not only an accounting matter. It is a decision about the kind of protection Europe wants to secure for its people, its territory and its future.



FIVE CONNECTED DIMENSIONS ARE AT STAKE



1

Material conditions. Temperature and water are not environmental chapters. They are the foundations that sustain population, health, the economy, infrastructures and security.



2

Budget. Financial decisions also determine which risks may be addressed and which will increase their future cost.



3

Time. Each year without sufficient reorientation can increase costs, reduce options and decrease reversibility.



4

Security. A comprehensive definition must include the conditions that make the territory habitable and enable life in common.



5

Governance. It is not enough to respond better. Decisions must also be oriented to prevent the need to respond from growing indefinitely.



THE FUNDAMENTAL QUESTION

Can Europe protect its people, its territory and its capacity to decide without adequately incorporating the conditions that are already reducing its present margin and future?



**THE FUTURE PROTECTION OF EUROPE
DEPENDS ON A PRESENT DECISION:
INTEGRATE MATERIAL CONDITIONS
AT THE HEART OF PRIORITIES.**



The territory does not wait.
Conditions are not negotiable.
Decisions are political.
Consequences are material.

Observation, synthesis
and analysis based on
available evidence.
Without attribution of intent.
Without predictions.
Only verifiable relationships.

13. CONCLUSION: PROTECTION CANNOT BE SEPARATED FROM ITS CONDITIONS

Europe is not starting from an absence of knowledge.

Since 2015, there has been explicit political recognition of the climate threat. In 2026, moreover, the available evidence makes it possible to observe its thermal, hydrological, territorial, health and economic manifestations in greater detail.

Nor is Europe starting from an absence of capacity.

The European Union has institutions, scientific knowledge, technical resources, financial instruments, regulation and coordination capacity.

The problem analyzed in this document lies elsewhere:

the distance between the material conditions being observed and the position they occupy when priorities are established.

Temperature and water are not merely climate indicators.

They directly condition health, agriculture, energy, infrastructure, productivity, habitability, the economy and security.

It is therefore difficult to consider a decision on protection and financing complete if those conditions do not occupy an explicit position in the calculation.

Defense, competitiveness, sovereignty, border control or budgetary discipline may constitute legitimate objectives.

But none of them exists outside the territory.

All require population, water, energy, functional infrastructure and thermal conditions compatible with their continuity.

The question that remains open is not whether Europe should abandon some priorities in order to adopt others.

It is more fundamental:

Can a protection strategy be considered complete if it does not place among its guiding conditions that on which everything it seeks to protect materially depends?

Time adds urgency to this question.

Political objectives can be reformulated.

Timelines can be extended.

Priorities can be renamed.

But accumulated deterioration does not reset when the document changes.

Each additional period without sufficient reorientation can reduce margin, increase costs and make it more difficult to recover what can still be recovered.

That is why protecting Europe's future does not begin only with greater capacity.

It begins with a correct relationship between **capacity, orientation and material conditions**.

Recognizing the signal is necessary.

Incorporating it into steering is the pending decision.

FINAL REFLECTION: PROTECT WHAT MAKES ALL PRIORITIES POSSIBLE

European architecture can continue expanding its technical, institutional and financial capacity.

But no architecture can stand if the conditions that sustain the population, the territory and the economy deteriorate faster than the response capacity can keep up.

ESSENTIAL REMINDERS



Temperature and water

are not environmental topics. They are material conditions that underlie all decisions.



Every financial decision

determines which risks may be addressed and which will increase their future cost.



Time is not neutral

when the conditions itself are deteriorating. Every year matters.



Complete security

includes the conditions that make life in common possible.



To govern

is to translate signals into priorities and to prevent the need to respond from growing indefinitely.



THE QUESTION THAT REMAINS:

Can Europe reorient its priorities before the conditions that allow it to protect its population, its territory and its decision-making capacity continue to diminish?

**PROTECTING EUROPE'S FUTURE
IS NOT ONLY ABOUT HAVING MORE CAPACITY.**

IT IS ABOUT ORIENTING IT CORRECTLY.



The future is not written in documents. It is linked to the relationship between what we observe, what we decide and the conditions that make it possible.

DECOUPLING BETWEEN THREAT AND PROTECTION

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The references are used to document the climate baseline, the political position analyzed, and some of the material conditions mentioned. The structural relationships developed in the document correspond to the author's analysis.

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